WOLFE

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THE PLAYBOOK

THE CONVERSATION PLAYBOOK

How to take any conversation from "hey" to genuinely connected, and what to say when it stalls.

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Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character, not a real person, and has no personal life story. This is general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy, medical, legal or financial advice, and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

INTRODUCTION

WHY CONVERSATIONS DIE

You match. You text. The first few messages go fine, then it slowly fades. Or you sit across from someone on a date and run out of things to say.

It feels like a personality problem. It is not. It is a **skills problem**, and skills can be learned.

Conversations die for three reasons:

Interview mode	You fire question after question and share nothing. It feels like a job interview.
Surface level	You stay on facts (work, weather, weekend) and never reach feelings or stories.
Fear of silence	You panic at a pause and say something forgettable, or nothing at all.

This playbook fixes all three with simple, repeatable tools. Read it once, then practise one chapter a day.

MINDSET · CHAPTER 1

WHY PEOPLE CONNECT

Before techniques, understand what is actually happening when two people click. It is rarely about perfect lines. It is about how the other person **feels** around you.

Safe	She feels she can relax, be herself and not be judged.
Seen	You noticed something real about her and showed it.
Interested	Your attention is on her, not on your phone or your performance.
Equal	You are not begging for approval and not trying to dominate. You are two people exploring each other.

THE REFRAME THAT REMOVES PRESSURE

You are not auditioning. You are checking whether you two enjoy each other. Either outcome is fine.

THE 3 THINGS YOU CONTROL

- Your curiosity (ask, listen, follow up).
- Your honesty (kindly).
- Your presence (phone away, calm voice).

THE 3 THINGS YOU DO NOT CONTROL

- Whether she is interested in you.
- Her mood or her day.
- How fast she replies.

CHAPTER 2

THE 3-LAYER RULE

Every conversation has three layers. Most people never leave the first.

Layer 1: Facts	"Where did you grow up?" "What do you do?" Safe, easy, forgettable.
Layer 2: Feelings	"What did you like about growing up there?" "What do you enjoy about your job?" This is where she lights up.
Layer 3: Meaning	"What did that teach you?" "Why does it matter to you?" This is where real connection happens.

Psychologist Arthur Aron and colleagues found in 1997 that gradually deeper, mutual sharing can create closeness even between strangers. The key words are **gradually** and **mutual**. You go deeper only as fast as she is comfortable, and you share too.

YOUR RULE

Spend a minute in Layer 1, then ask one Layer 2 question. Only go to Layer 3 when the mood allows it.

CHAPTER 3

ECHO, DIG, SHARE

A simple loop that keeps any conversation moving.

Echo	Repeat her key word with curiosity. She says "I just got back from Lisbon." You say "Lisbon! What took you there?"
Dig	Ask about the feeling or the reason. "What was the best part?" "Why that city?"
Share	Offer a short story or opinion of your own. "I have always wanted to go. I got lost in Istanbul once, completely lost."

Then loop back to Echo. This loop alone turns a Q&A into a conversation.

EXAMPLE

She: I started pottery classes last month.

You: Pottery! (Echo) What made you try it? (Dig)

She: I needed something that was not a screen.

You: I get that. I spend all day at a laptop and I started cooking for the same reason. (Share) What is the hardest part so far?

CHAPTER 4

ESCAPE INTERVIEW MODE

If you ask three questions in a row without sharing, you are interviewing her. The fix is the **1:1 rule**: for every question you ask, give one piece of yourself.

INTERVIEW MODE (BAD)

✕ "Where do you work?" "Do you like it?" "How long?" "Any siblings?"

CONVERSATION MODE (GOOD)

What do you do? ... Oh nice, I am in [field]. I actually fell into it by accident. How did you end up there?

QUICK TEST

Look at your last 3 messages. If all three end with a question mark, add a statement about you.

SKILL · CHAPTER 5

LISTEN LIKE IT MATTERS

Most people listen while waiting for their turn. Real listening is rare, and she will notice it.

Stop planning	Do not prepare your next line while she speaks. You will find it when she finishes.
Listen for the emotion	Notice how she says it: excited, tired, proud, worried. Respond to that.
Use small signals	Nod, "mm", "really?", "go on". They show you are with her.
Pause before answering	A one-second pause shows you took it in.
Remember details	Her sister's name, her favourite place, her big meeting. Bring it up later.

THE DETAIL TRICK

After a conversation, write down two details she mentioned. Next time, open with one of them.

> **How did the presentation go? You were nervous about it last time.**
> Shows you were listening

LISTENING MISTAKES

- ✕ Finishing her sentences.
- ✕ Checking your phone "just once".
- ✕ Turning every story into your story.
- ✕ Giving advice when she only wanted to be heard.
- ✕ Nodding while thinking about something else. People can tell.

EXERCISE

In your next conversation with anyone, ask one follow-up question about something they said earlier. Count how their face changes.

SKILL · CHAPTER 6

TELL A STORY IN 60 SECONDS

Stories make you memorable. The good news: you do not need dramatic ones. A small, honest, funny moment works better than a big boast.

THE 4-PART STORY

1. Set the scene	"Last summer I decided I could fix my own bike."
2. The problem	"Forty minutes in, I realised I had taken it apart and had no idea how it went together."
3. The twist	"A ten-year-old neighbour came over and quietly put it back together."
4. The point	"Lesson learned: ask for help earlier, and never underestimate ten-year-olds."

Keep it under a minute. End with a short line, then hand the conversation back: "Have you ever done something like that?"

BUILD YOUR STORY BANK

Prepare five stories before you meet people. Write a one-line summary of each:

- A funny travel mishap.
- A time you failed and learned something.
- Something you are proud of (told humbly).
- A weird job or school memory.
- A moment of kindness you saw or received.

- ✕ Do not exaggerate or invent. If it is made up, it will show.
- ✕ Do not tell long stories with many side details.
- ✕ Do not make yourself the hero every time.

SKILL · CHAPTER 7

HUMOUR AND PLAYFULNESS

You do not need to be a comedian. You need to be relaxed and willing to be a little playful. Three easy forms:

Observational	Notice something funny in the moment. "That waiter is clearly judging my coffee order."
Self-deprecating	Light, not sad. "I cook, but only three dishes. All of them pasta."
Playful teasing	Gentle, mutual, never about something she is sensitive about. "You ordered the same thing twice? Bold strategy."

SAFE TEASING RULES

- Tease things she is proud of, never insecure about.
- If she looks uncomfortable, stop and soften immediately.
- Make sure she can tease you back.
- Smile when you do it. Tone matters.

EXAMPLE

SHE
I always arrive early. It is a problem.

YOU
A problem? That sounds like a superpower. I am the person who sprints in at the last second.

SHE
Ha, I would be stressed just watching you.

- ✕ Jokes about her appearance.
- ✕ Sarcasm that sounds like criticism.
- ✕ Offensive or crude jokes to "test" her.
- ✕ Laughing at your own joke too hard.

SKILL · CHAPTER 8

COMPLIMENTS THAT LAND

A good compliment is specific, sincere and about something she chose, not just something she was born with.

WEAK VS STRONG

Weak	"You are beautiful." (Generic. She hears it often.)
Stronger	"You have a great laugh. It made the whole table look over."
Weak	"You are smart."
Stronger	"The way you explained that was so clear. I understood it first time."

COMPLIMENT FORMULA

Notice a specific thing + **say why** it stands out. Then move on without waiting for a reaction.

> **I love how passionate you get about your garden. It is contagious.**

> **You have great taste in music. I added three songs to my playlist already.**

> **You are really good at making people feel comfortable.**

- ✕ Compliment overload. One or two a date is plenty.
- ✕ Compliments that are really requests.
- ✕ Looking for a reaction or fishing for a "thank you".

CHAPTER 9

30 BETTER QUESTIONS

Keep these in your notes app. Ask them naturally, not like a checklist.

EASY (LAYER 1 TO 2)

1. What is the best thing you have eaten recently?
2. What is a small thing that always makes your day better?
3. If you had a free Saturday, what would you do?
4. What was the last show or book you could not stop?
5. What is your go-to comfort food?
6. What is the best trip you have ever taken?
7. What is something you are weirdly good at?
8. Are you a morning or night person, and how bad is it?
9. What is on your playlist you would be embarrassed by?
10. What would your perfect Sunday look like?

WARM (LAYER 2)

11. What was your favourite thing about growing up where you did?
12. What is something you are proud of that no one asks about?
13. Who has influenced you the most?
14. What do you do when you need to recharge?
15. What did you want to be when you were ten?
16. What is the best advice you have ever received?
17. What kind of people do you feel most yourself around?
18. What are you looking forward to this year?
19. What is a skill you wish you had?

20	What is the happiest memory that comes to mind right now?

DEEP (LAYER 3, USE SPARINGLY)

21	What is something you used to believe that you do not anymore?
22	What do you wish people understood about you?
23	When do you feel most alive?
24	What is a risk you took that changed things?
25	What are you still figuring out?
26	What is something you are afraid to say out loud?
27	What does a good relationship look like to you?
28	What would you do differently if no one was watching?
29	What do you value more as you get older?
30	What is a moment that shaped who you are?

IMPORTANT

Always share your own answer too. Deep questions only work when it is a trade, not an interrogation.

BONUS · CHAPTER 10

50 MORE CONVERSATION STARTERS

Use these when you run out of ideas. Mix them with your own.

FUN

1. If you could instantly master any skill, what would it be?
2. What would be the title of your autobiography?
3. What is the strangest food you have eaten and would eat again?
4. Which fictional world would you want to live in?
5. What is your most irrational fear?
6. What is the best gift you have ever received?
7. What was your first job and what did it teach you?
8. If you had to eat one cuisine forever, which?
9. What is your guilty pleasure show?
10. What is the best concert or event you have been to?
11. Which decade would you time-travel to?
12. What is your most-used app besides messaging?
13. Are you a planner or a go-with-the-flow person?
14. What is the funniest thing that happened to you this year?
15. What would you do with a free month off work?

LIFE AND GOALS

16. What is a goal you are working toward right now?
17. What does success look like to you in five years?
18. What do you do that makes you lose track of time?

19 What is something you would try if you knew you could not fail?

20 What was the best decision you ever made?

21 What is one habit you are proud of?

22 What is something you learned the hard way?

23 What is the most meaningful compliment you have received?

24 Who is someone you really admire and why?

25 What would your younger self think of you now?

26 What is your favourite thing about your city?

27 Where do you feel most at peace?

28 What are you reading, watching or learning right now?

29 What do you like most about your friends?

30 What does a good day look like for you?

CONNECTION

31 What do you value most in friendships?

32 What makes you feel appreciated?

33 What is your favourite way to spend time with someone?

34 What is a tradition you love?

35 What is something small that makes you feel cared for?

36 What did your family teach you that you still use?

37 What is the most adventurous thing you have done?

38 What kind of conversations do you enjoy most?

39 How do you like to celebrate good news?

40 What is something you are grateful for this week?

41 What do you wish you had more time for?

42 What is a compliment you love to receive?

43	What is the best part of being your age?
44	What does "home" mean to you?
45	What would make this week a great one?

Some of these are too deep for a first message. Use the Easy list first and go deeper as the mood allows.

CHAPTER 11

WHAT TO SAY WHEN SHE OPENS UP

This is where most people freeze. She shares something personal and you say "oh, that is rough" or change the subject. Use the **ARAS** steps:

A: Acknowledge	"That sounds like it was really hard." / "That must have felt amazing."
R: Reflect	Say back what you heard. "So you moved alone at 22 and had to figure it out."
A: Ask	"What was that like for you?" / "How did you get through it?"
S: Share	A short, relevant moment from your life. Keep it brief and return the focus to her.

EXAMPLE

She: My dad was sick last year. It was a rough time.

You: I am sorry, that sounds exhausting. (Acknowledge) You were looking after everyone while holding it together. (Reflect) How are you doing now? (Ask)

- ✕ Do not try to fix it ("You should just...").
- ✕ Do not one-up her ("Oh, mine was worse").
- ✕ Do not rush to a joke to escape the discomfort.
- ✕ Do not change the subject.

CHAPTER 12

5 WAYS TO BEAT AWKWARD SILENCE

A pause is not a failure. Two seconds of silence feels like ten to you and almost nothing to her. If it still feels stuck, use one of these:

1. Breathe and smile	Do nothing for three seconds. Comfortable people tolerate silence.
2. The callback	Return to something she said earlier. "Wait, earlier you mentioned [thing]. Tell me more."
3. Observe the moment	"This place has great lighting." / "That is the loudest espresso machine I have ever heard."
4. The pivot question	"Can I switch topics? What is something you are excited about this month?"
5. The honest line	"I lost my train of thought. Your turn to pick a topic." Honesty charms people.

PREPARE IN ADVANCE

Pick two callbacks and one pivot question before every conversation. Confidence is mostly preparation.

CHAPTER 13

"TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF"

She says "so, tell me about yourself" and your mind goes blank. Use the **Present, Past, Passion** formula. Aim for 20 to 30 seconds, then hand it back.

Present	What you do now, in one line.
Past	One interesting thing that shaped you.
Passion	Something you love, with energy.

EXAMPLE

> **I run a small [business/role] (Present). I grew up in [place], which is why I am obsessed with [thing] (Past). Right now I am trying to get better at [hobby], badly, but I love it (Passion). What about you?**

- ✕ Do not recite your CV.
- ✕ Do not brag or list achievements.
- ✕ Do not talk for more than 30 seconds.
- ✕ Always end by asking her back.

CHAPTER 14

FROM TEXTING TO TALKING

A good chat over text should lead to a real meeting. Do not stay in text-land for weeks.

Rule of 3 days	After about 3 days of good chatting, suggest meeting.
Be specific	"Coffee Thursday at 6?" beats "We should hang out sometime."
Offer two options	"Thursday or Saturday?" makes saying yes easy.
Accept a no gracefully	"No worries, take care." Never argue or guilt-trip.

> **I am enjoying this. Want to continue it over coffee Thursday or Saturday?**

FROM MATCH TO MEETING

Online chats follow a simple path: **Open → Connect → Plan.** Aim to move through it in about 3 to 5 days.

Day 1: Open	A specific, light first message. Ask one easy question.
Day 1-3: Connect	Use Echo, Dig, Share. Find one or two things you genuinely have in common.
Day 3-5: Plan	Suggest a specific meet-up. Offer two options.

FULL EXAMPLE 1: A GOOD CHAT

YOU
That photo from the lake. Please tell me it was as good as it looks.

SHE
Ha, it was. Lake Como last summer.

YOU
Jealous. What was the best part?

SHE
Probably the boat trip. We got completely lost.

YOU
Lost is when the good stories start. I once took the wrong train in Italy and ended up in a village with one bar and one very opinionated barman.

SHE
That sounds amazing. What did you order?

YOU
Whatever he told me to. Best coffee of my life. Do you travel a lot?

FULL EXAMPLE 2: MOVING TO A PLAN

YOU
I am enjoying this. Want to continue it over coffee this week?

SHE
Sure, maybe. I am pretty busy.

YOU
No problem. Thursday evening or Saturday morning, whichever suits you?

SHE
Saturday morning works.

YOU
Great. 10:30 at [place]. I will message you when I arrive.

FULL EXAMPLE 3: ONE-WORD ANSWERS

YOU
How was your weekend?

SHE
Good.

YOU
Good as in relaxing or good as in "I need a holiday from my holiday"?

SHE
Haha, definitely the second.

REMEMBER

If she keeps giving one-word answers across many messages, she may not be interested. Do not push. Thank her and move on.

10 TRICKY MOMENTS AND WHAT TO SAY (1/2)

1. SHE GIVES ONE-WORD ANSWERS

Okay, I am going to ask a better question. What is the best thing you ate this week?

Makes it easy and fun to answer

2. "WHAT ARE YOU LOOKING FOR?"

Honestly, someone I can laugh with and be myself around. A real connection. What about you?

Honest, short, hands it back

3. SHE SHARES BAD NEWS

I am really sorry. That sounds hard. Do you want to talk about it, or would you rather think about something else for a bit?

Gives her the choice

4. YOU DISAGREE WITH HER

I see it a bit differently, but I love that you have such strong views. Why do you feel that way?

Respectful disagreement

5. YOU HAVE NOTHING IN COMMON

We are clearly different. I am more [x], you are more [y]. Teach me something about your world.

Turns difference into curiosity

10 TRICKY MOMENTS AND WHAT TO SAY (2/2)

6. SHE ASKS ABOUT YOUR EX

It ended, we are fine, we wanted different things. I learned a lot from it. How about you?

Short, positive, no bashing

7. YOU GET NERVOUS MID-CONVERSATION

I will be honest, I am a little nervous. That is a good sign for me. Let me start again.

Honesty disarms nerves

8. SHE IS DISTRACTED / ON HER PHONE

Looks like you have a lot going on. Want to pick this up another time?

Calm, respectful, no sulking

9. A COMPLIMENT YOU DO NOT KNOW HOW TO ANSWER

Thank you, that made my day.

Simple and sincere

10. RECONNECTING AFTER A LONG GAP

Hey, I came across [thing] and thought of you. How have you been?

No guilt, just warmth

CHAPTER 18

END ON A HIGH

The last 30 seconds are what people remember. Leave while it is still good.

I have to run, but I loved this. Let us do it again soon.
In person

I had a great time. Same again next week?
After a date

I have to head off. Let us pick this up tomorrow.
Over text

Do not wait for the energy to drop. Ending early leaves her wanting more, in the healthiest way.

CHAPTER 19

10 CONVERSATION KILLERS

- ✕ Interrogating with question after question.
- ✕ Talking only about yourself.
- ✕ Checking your phone while she talks.
- ✕ Interrupting to finish her sentence.
- ✕ Giving advice she did not ask for.
- ✕ Complaining about exes, work or the world.
- ✕ Fake agreement. Be honest, politely.
- ✕ Over-complimenting. One genuine compliment beats ten.
- ✕ Dropping a heavy topic too early.
- ✕ Trying to impress instead of connect.

HANDLING NERVES

Nerves are normal. They are not a sign you will fail. They are a sign you care. Here is how to manage them:

Slow breathing	In for 4 seconds, out for 6. Do this before and during.
Reframe	Say "I am excited" instead of "I am nervous". The body feels almost the same.
Focus outward	Put your attention on her: her words, her face, her story. Less time in your own head.
Move first	A short walk before you arrive burns off adrenaline.
Prepare an opener	Have your first sentence and first question ready.
Accept mistakes	You will stumble sometimes. Smile and carry on. People like humans.

THE 5-MINUTE PRE-CONVERSATION ROUTINE

- [ ] Drink water.
- [ ] Three slow breaths.
- [ ] Stand tall, relax shoulders.
- [ ] Remind yourself: curiosity, not performance.
- [ ] Smile before you walk in.

LONG-TERM FIX

Confidence is built by doing. Have one small conversation a day with anyone and your comfort grows quickly.

HANDLING "NO" AND SILENCE

Rejection is part of dating for everyone. How you handle it shapes your confidence and your reputation.

Accept it quickly	A no is information, not an insult. Do not argue or persuade.
Respond gracefully	"No problem, thanks for being honest. Take care."
Do not take it as a verdict	It says what she wants, not what you are worth.
Learn, do not obsess	Ask yourself once what you could improve, then move on.

GRACEFUL EXIT LINES

> **Thanks for telling me. I appreciate the honesty. Take care.**

> **No hard feelings at all. It was good to meet you.**

> **All good, I enjoyed chatting. Best of luck.**

- ✕ Arguing or asking "why?" repeatedly.
- ✕ Insulting her afterwards.
- ✕ Sending long angry messages.
- ✕ Continuing to contact her after a clear no.

REMEMBER

People remember how you leave. A kind exit builds respect, even from someone who said no.

YOUR STORY BANK

Write one line for each story you can tell. Practise saying them out loud.

MY 5 STORIES

MY 5 FAVOURITE QUESTIONS

MY "PRESENT, PAST, PASSION" ANSWER

CONVERSATION REVIEW

After each conversation or date, answer these. This is how skills grow fast.

WHAT WENT WELL

WHAT FELT AWKWARD

ONE THING TO TRY NEXT TIME

DID I...

- [ ] Share as much as I asked?
- [ ] Follow up on something she said?
- [ ] Stay calm during silence?
- [ ] Keep my phone away?
- [ ] End on a high?

30-DAY CONVERSATION CHALLENGE

One small task a day. Do them with anyone: coworkers, friends, strangers, matches. Tick them off.

- [ ] Day 1: Smile and greet three people.
- [ ] Day 2: Learn one new person's name and a detail.
- [ ] Day 3: Echo a word and ask about it.
- [ ] Day 4: Ask one Layer 2 question.
- [ ] Day 5: Share a short story.
- [ ] Day 6: Pause 2 seconds before answering.
- [ ] Day 7: Review the week.
- [ ] Day 8: Give one specific compliment.
- [ ] Day 9: Use the 1:1 rule.
- [ ] Day 10: Start a conversation in a queue.
- [ ] Day 11: Practise ARAS with a friend.
- [ ] Day 12: Tolerate a 3-second silence.
- [ ] Day 13: Send a first message you are proud of.
- [ ] Day 14: Review the fortnight.

30-DAY CHALLENGE, CONTINUED

- [ ] Day 15: Tell your best story.
- [ ] Day 16: Use light humour once.
- [ ] Day 17: Ask a Deep question (with a share).
- [ ] Day 18: Follow up on a detail from last time.
- [ ] Day 19: Practise your Present, Past, Passion answer.
- [ ] Day 20: End a conversation on a high.
- [ ] Day 21: Review the three weeks.
- [ ] Day 22: Suggest a specific plan.
- [ ] Day 23: Practise a graceful "no".
- [ ] Day 24: Go on a first date or meet-up.
- [ ] Day 25: Review your date with the worksheet.
- [ ] Day 26: Reconnect with someone you lost touch with.
- [ ] Day 27: Practise your nerve routine.
- [ ] Day 28: Teach someone a skill or tell them a story.
- [ ] Day 29: Re-read your story bank and refresh it.
- [ ] Day 30: Write down what changed.

FINISH LINE

Thirty days of small, honest practice will change how you talk to people. Keep going. Skills compound.

CHEAT SHEET · CHAPTER 26

ONE-PAGE QUICK REFERENCE

3 layers	Facts, Feelings, Meaning. Move one step at a time.
Echo, Dig, Share	Repeat a word, ask why, share your own.
1:1 rule	For every question, share something.
ARAS	Acknowledge, Reflect, Ask, Share.
Silence	Breathe, callback, observe, pivot, be honest.
About you	Present, Past, Passion. Then ask her.
Plan	Specific day and place, two options.
End	Leave on a high.
No	Accept it kindly and move on.

CORE IDEA

Be curious. Be honest. Be kind. Respect boundaries. Everything else is a tool.

BE CALM.

BE CURIOUS.

BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe